



they contain, all in an effort to look cool, or knowledgeable.

Facebook is like the world's largest college cafeteria, and also the world's biggest photo album. We have to let people know what we're doing, how cute our Gen O babies are, what we ate last night, how delicious it was to wash it down with wine...some will even describe what it was like coming out the other end... While Gen -1 (us, we, you, I) remembers being paranoid about security and privacy at one time, we ourselves are now throwing our privacy out the window and shoving our business in every face who friend's us. One can only imagine what Gen O will be up to...

We already live in a world where a tweet is not the sweet sound a bird makes, and where the people you know the most details about are often not the people you would call good friends. Is that where we're headed? Knowing everything there is to know about people you never meet, and not knowing yourself, your family or kids unless they post something online? It certainly feels like we're becoming more anti-social in the age of social networking!

Raised by tech

Coming back to the iPad kids I mentioned earlier, I don't know a single tablet owner, who also happens to be a mother or father, that doesn't extol the wonders of iPad parenting. It's simple really: once a kid's about two years old, just hand him/her an iPad, and revel in the sweet serenity of them being too enthralled to howl and bawl and drive you up a wall. My apologies,



Gen O is starting younger than ever before

to anyone thinking of dashing off indignant emails to me, explaining how you're encouraging your child's creativity – I'm sure you're the exception!

What are we really instilling in children though? It's OK to waste time with frivolous technology, so long as you do it on your own,

and leave us alone? Don't get me wrong, there are 6-year-olds out there who know more about technology than I did when I was 18! Gen O is not just smart, it's seriously out-pacing the previous generation's adaptability to technology. They learn quicker, they take to new devices like a duck to water and they are up on all the latest developments. We have Digit readers as young as 8 who are already coding, thanks to them being born with a digital spoon, so to speak.

Weak geniuses?

Various studies across the globe have shown that our new digital lifestyle is harming our health. We sit around more often than we walk or run, work all the time, eat unhealthily, brainlessly stare at the million channels on offer (online and on TV), are sleep deprived and fall sick easily. I should know, I'm describing myself and most of Team Digit, our friends, relatives, and just about anyone under the age of 35. I spend more time IM-ing my friends and family than I do chatting with them face-to-face – who has the time to actually “meet” anymore?

One doesn't miss what one doesn't know, of course, and if we're already mostly digitally present for our own lives, what will a generation of people who are brought up with technology all around them do?

Although we may be growing smarter as a civilisation, it's not street smarts that we're imparting. Studies have shown that the human race is becoming weaker than ever before when it comes to handling crises and catastrophes. We humans got through two World Wars and a Cold War, and yet I've seen teens whose brains almost seem to shut down the minute they come across a few of life's hurdles. They can code software, but are left scratching their heads with the smallest real-world problems. If anything, the distractions of trying to do a million things at once is probably the biggest hurdle that lies ahead for Gen O – regardless of what they will be doing, I'm quite sure they'll have to “multi-task”. Jack of all, master of none.

DUNNING-KRUGER EFFECT

Charles Darwin once said “Ignorance more frequently begets confidence than does knowledge”. David Dunning and Justin Kruger of Cornell University did a study of undergraduate students, testing them for various skills including humour, logic and grammar. After testing the students, they shared a student's test results with him/her and then asked the student to rate where in the rankings they had placed.

What they found was that the weaker students tended to seriously overestimate their ranking, whereas the high scorers tended to underestimate themselves. Thus, they concluded that people tend to suffer from “illusory superiority”, or basically, the dumber you are, the smarter you think you are in relation to the rest of the world. This is what usually manifests itself on

social networks, forums, and most public places online these days. People love to comment and offer their 2 cents, genuinely believing that they're being witty, funny, logical, or adding value in some way; they're not; most of the time.

A follow-up study found that with a little teaching, the worst students were quickly able to estimate their rank more precisely, even if they didn't fare much better in the tests. What this basically means is that after a reality check, we're better at realising what we do know and what we don't. The only problem is... a reality check from real-world friends, parents, teachers, people you respect, sure; but when was the last time you paid any attention to someone online who insulted you for your lack of knowledge?